



More Boxes, Same Verdict

Ballot Length and Satisfaction Across Five Cohorts of Year 7 Electives

Runa Adegoke · Bram Ntuli — School of Emergent Priorities

Background

Every Year 7 timetable begins with a ranked ballot, and every school assumes a longer form gives the allocation algorithm more to work with. Five years into an expanded ballot, nobody had checked whether the extra ranked choices change what students actually receive.

Aims

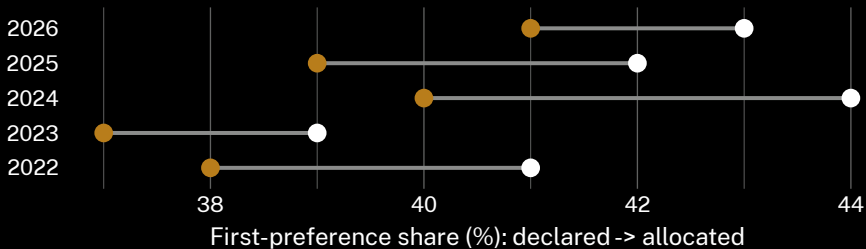
- Compare post-allocation satisfaction between 3-choice and 5-choice ballot cohorts
- Test whether ballot length shifts the share of students placed in their declared first preference
- Establish whether the declared-to-allocated gap narrows once more choices are collected

Methods

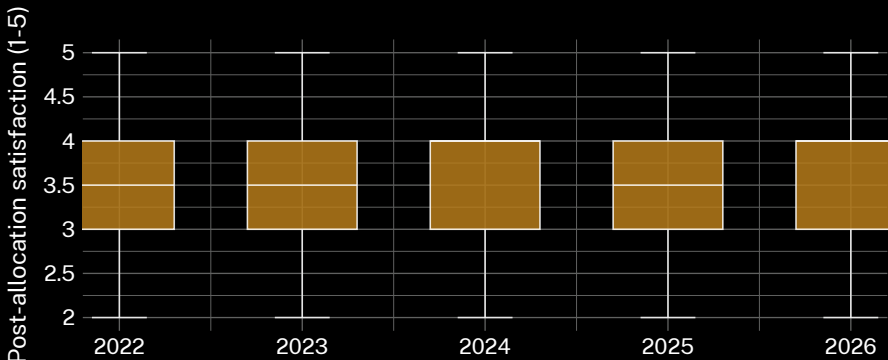
- n = 612 Year 7 students across five intake cohorts (2022–2026) · self-report survey · 4-week post-allocation window
- Ballot length rolled by cohort: 3-choice through 2023, 5-choice from 2024 · allocation algorithm and seat caps held constant throughout
- Satisfaction on a pre-registered 5-point instrument; declared and allocated first preferences logged from the enrolment system

Results

Post-allocation satisfaction is statistically indistinguishable between 3-choice (M = 3.41/5) and 5-choice (M = 3.38/5) cohorts ($t(610) = 0.44$, $p = .66$). The extra ranked boxes reorder which subject becomes the second-preference disappointment; they do not change how many students get it.



First-preference allocation share held between 37% and 41% across all five cohorts (2022–2026); the 2024 ballot-length change produced no measurable shift ($\Delta = 0.6$ pp, n.s.).



Satisfaction quartiles overlap fully across all five cohorts; the 2024 ballot-length change moves neither the median nor the spread.

Discussion & conclusions

Ballot length changes what students are asked, not what they get: the declared-to-allocated gap holds within a point of its five-year mean regardless of form. A widely trusted proxy for student voice moves the paperwork, not the seat, and the satisfaction distribution above shows why — whatever a longer ballot changes about the ranking exercise, it leaves the lived experience of the timetable untouched. Next: trial disclosing seat caps before ranking, rather than after.

References

1. Agarwal, N., & Somaini, P. (2020). Revealed preference analysis of school choice models. *Annual Review of Economics*, 12, 471–501. doi:10.1146/annurev-economics-082019-112339
2. Haeringer, G., & Klijn, F. (2009). Constrained school choice. *Journal of Economic Theory*, 144(5), 1921–1947. doi:10.1016/j.jet.2009.05.002
3. Klijn, F., Pais, J., & Vorsatz, M. (2019). Static versus dynamic deferred acceptance in school choice: theory and experiment. *Games and Economic Behavior*, 113, 147–163. doi:10.1016/j.geb.2018.08.009
4. Lee, S. (2022). Preference learning in school choice problems. arXiv:2202.08366.
5. Tolan, A., & Sabel, R. (2026). More Words, More Drift: Response Elaboration Outperforms Every Other Predictor in the Strategic Drift Survey's New Second-Layer Score. Sloped University Office of Research Outputs. doi:10.5555/slop.4v9cxa

We thank the participating schools' enrolment offices for retrieving five years of ballot archives. Ballots and satisfaction responses de-identified before analysis; no student contacted directly.

Contact: runa.adegoke@sloped.university · Office of Research Outputs

@sloped.university · #slopedU